

San José State University
Department of Political Science
Pols 16. Power and Ideas in American Politics
Class number: POLS 16-81
Section: 31219
Summer 2026

COURSE AND CONTACT INFORMATION

Instructor: Robert Ovetz, Ph.D.

Phone: Please email me for my personal phone number in cases of personal emergency Email: robert.ovetz@sjsu.edu

Office hours: Tues 12-1 pm (Zoom) and Thurs 12-1 pm (in person). No appointments are needed. Please email another proposed a day and time M-F 9-6 pm for an appointment by phone. **Do not text.** Office location: On line

Class days and time: By prior appointment only

COURSE DESCRIPTION

Study of power, institutions, and creative ideas in American political thought. Engages work of intellect and imagination in political documents, essays, speeches, letters, short works of fiction, poems, and manifestos. Satisfies requirements for C2: Humanities + US2: US Constitution + US3: California Government.

SJSU GE GUIDELINES

In this course, you will be exposed to alternative interpretations of the historical events and political processes that have shaped the social, economic, and political system in which you live. This course will provide a multicultural framework, including both conflict and consensus perspectives, of the choices and options available to individuals and groups in their social, economic, and political relations. The focus of the course is the growth of a multicultural society and the interactions, including cooperation and conflict, as these many and varied peoples have dealt with social economic, and political issues.

WORKLOAD AND CREDIT HOUR REQUIREMENTS

Success in this course is based on the expectation that students will spend, for each unit of credit, a minimum of 45 hours over the length of the course (normally 3 hours per unit per week with 1 of the hours used for lecture) for instruction or preparation/studying or course related activities as described in the syllabus.

COURSE LEARNING OUTCOMES

Course Learning Outcomes (CLOs)

GE Area C2: Humanities

Area C Arts and Humanities courses help students to respond subjectively as well as objectively to aesthetic experiences and to develop an understanding of the integrity of both emotional and intellectual responses. C2

Humanities courses encourage students to analyze and appreciate works of philosophical, historical, literary, aesthetic, and cultural importance.

GE Area C2 Learning Outcomes

Upon successful completion of a C2 course, students should be able to:

1. analyze and understand works of philosophical and humanistic importance, including their temporal and cultural dimensions;
2. explore and articulate their own subjective aesthetic and intellectual responses to such texts; 3. analyze and assess ideas of value, meaning, and knowledge, as produced within the humanistic disciplines; and
4. research and write effective analyses of works of the human intellect and imagination

Writing Practice: Students will write a minimum of 1500 words in a language and style appropriate to the discipline.

American Institutions US2: US Constitution, and US3: California Government

The American Institutions (AI) requirement is based on the premise that any student graduating from the CSU should have an understanding of the history and governmental institutions of the United States and the State of California. This requirement, which was put in place by the State of California, is laid out in California State University Executive Order 1061. The original mandate appears in the State Education Code Title 5, Section 40404.

US2 Learning Outcomes

To fulfill the requirements for U.S. Constitution, students should be able to explain how political decisions are made, what the consequences of such decisions are for individuals and society, and how individuals and groups may affect the decisionmaking process.

As students explore the meaning and content of the democratic process as it has evolved in the United States, at a minimum they should be able to evaluate:

- A. the foundations of the political system, including the evolution of the U.S. Constitution, political culture, separation of powers, federalism, and relations among various levels of government. Students will also analyze the evolving institutions of government, including a study of the powers of the President, Congress, and the Judiciary as well as the bureaucracy.
- B. the links between the people and the political system of the United States, including voting and other forms of participation, as well as other content areas such as tribal governments, political parties, interest/lobbying groups, and public opinion and socialization. Students should also analyze the rights and obligations of citizens, which may include the tension between various freedoms of expression, including issues related to censorship and freedom of speech, due process, and the maintenance of order.
- C. connections to issues of justice/injustice, including the efforts to end racial, gender, and other forms of discriminatory practices in both the public and private sectors.

US3 Learning Outcomes

To fulfill the requirements for California Government, students should be able to explain how political decisions are made at the state and local level taking into account the diverse cultures, communities, and environments of California, including the impact of demographic changes on the history and politics of the state and the nation.

As students explore the operations of government at the state level, they should be able to evaluate: A. the foundations of the California political system, the similarities and differences between the California and

U.S. Constitutions, and the relationship between state and local government in California.

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B. the evolving relationships of state and local government with the federal government, such as the relationship with tribal governments; the generation and resolution of conflicts; the establishment of cooperative processes under the constitutions of both the state and nation; and the political processes involved.

General Education Program Learning Outcomes (GEPLOs)

1. To develop students' core competencies for academic, personal, creative, and professional pursuits.
2. To enact the university's commitment to diversity, inclusion, and justice by ensuring that students have the knowledge and skills to serve and contribute to the well-being of local and global communities and the environment.
3. To offer students integrated, multidisciplinary, and innovative study in which they pose challenging questions, address complex issues, and develop cooperative and creative responses.

More information about the General Education Program Learning Outcomes (PLOs) can be found on the GE website (<https://sjsu.edu/>)

Learning Outcomes (LOs)	How the LOs Will be Assessed			
	Key Concepts & Questions	In Class Reflections	Reflection Paper	SJSU Port Huron Paper
CLO 1	√	√	√	√
CLO 2			√	√
CLO 3	√	√	√	√
CLO 4			√	√
GEPLOs 1	√	√		
GEPLOs 2			√	√
GEPLOs 3	√	√	√	√

COURSE REQUIREMENTS AND ASSIGNMENTS

Important Dates

Mon 7/6—First day of class

Wed 7/8—**What is Power? Key Concepts** due on Canvas by 11:59 pm

Fri 7/10—**Authority Key Concepts** due on Canvas by 11:59 pm

Fri 7/17—**Democracy & Dictatorship Key Concepts** due on Canvas by 11:59 pm

Fri 7/24—**Imperialism & War Key Concepts** due on Canvas by 11:59 pm

Mon 7/27—**Reflection Paper** due on Canvas by 11:59 pm

Fri 7/31—**Social Control and Divisions Key Concepts** due on Canvas by 11:59 pm

Wed 8/5—**Future Prospects Key Concepts** due on Canvas by 11:59 pm

Fri 8/7— Last day of class; **SJSU Port Huron Paper** and all late Readings Key Concepts, and Reflection

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Paper due on Canvas by 11:59 pm

GRADING INFORMATION

Assignments Percentage (100 total points each) Readings Key Concepts & Questions 30 Reflection Paper 30 SJSU Port Huron Paper 40

Total 100

Grading Scale

A plus 96-100

A 93-95

A minus 90-92

B plus 86-89

B 83-85

B minus 80-82

C plus 76-79

C 73-75

C minus 70-72

D 60-69

F 0-59

Student Evaluation and Grading Policies

- There are no exams in this class.
- 10 percent will be deducted for each **week** that the Key Concepts, Reflection Paper, Draft Thesis, and Final Reflection Paper are turned in late. A period of seven days or less is consider one week. • Late Key Concepts, Reflection Paper, Draft Thesis, and Final Reflection Paper must be turned in late no later than the day of the Final Exam by 11:59 pm. **No late assignments will be taken after that time.** • The lowest grade for the Key Concepts will be automatically **dropped** in Canvas. • Please contact me about missed assignments due to a verifiable demonstrable medical, religious, or university related activities. A verifiable demonstrable excuse should be related to a medical, religious, or university related events only. Please contact me **in advance** and as soon as possible and provide appropriate documentation. Travel, work, loss of wifi, or other exams are unfortunately not considered verifiable demonstrable excuses. Any requests once the course has ended **will not be accepted.** • Assignments **cannot be resubmitted or regraded** after it is graded.
- Be sure to check your grades on Canvas closely. If there are any questions about specific assignments other than the final exam they must be made to me **no later than** the end of the last day of the course. • Note that your grade in Canvas is only for the graded assignments at that point in time and are subject to change with each new graded assignment up until the final grade is officially posted. To estimate your grade at any point during the semester use the Canvas grade sheet tool to estimate their grade by filling in

future ungraded assignments.

- When required, writing assignments must be cut and pasted into the assignment text box to be graded.
Do not post a link. **No assignments will be accepted by email.**
- Grades will be rounded up to the next letter only when the difference is .49 or less.

Canvas

For help with using Canvas please see the Canvas Student Resources page at: https://www.sjsu.edu/ecampus/teaching-tools/canvas/student_resources/. If you need immediate help please contact the Canvas Help at the tab on the left side of the Canvas page.

What To Do If You Miss Class

It is possible that students may miss class for a range of reasons from being ill to changes in their work schedules. For this reason, I do not take attendance. However, if you miss class it is your sole responsibility to get caught up by asking a classmate to borrow their notes and find out what you missed. I do not provide notes for missed classes.

Once you have a chance to get caught up on the missed class I am happy to help you during office hours to talk with me about any questions you have about what was covered in that class so I can help you get caught up.

If you miss an In Class Learning Activity or Quiz it is important to read the demonstrable excuse policy in the syllabus above and provide documentation if you are claiming that. Remember that In Class Learning Activities **cannot** be made up. However, you may miss two of them for any reason without permission. Two missed Learning Activities will automatically be dropped in Canvas.

If you have any further questions please do come to office hours so I can help you there.

COURSE MATERIALS

Required Readings

All the required course readings can be found in the course modules on Canvas. It is required to complete the readings for each class topic **before** the first day of that class topic.

Other Resources

The CQ Researcher and ABC-CLIO American Government databases available through the SJSU library website are good reference resources for topics covered in this class.

LIBRARY LIAISON

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Please contact the Political Science librarian Essy Barroso-Ramirez to answer questions and provide help with research, citations, and other library needs. Essy can be reached by email at essy.barroso@ramirez@sjsu.edu, 408-808-2041, and <https://libguides.sjsu.edu/politicalscience>

UNIVERSITY POLICIES

Per University Policy s16-9, university-wide policy information relevant to all courses, such as student responsibilities, academic integrity, accommodations, dropping and adding, consent for recording of class, etc. and available student services (e.g. learning assistance, counseling, and other resources) are listed on [Syllabus Information web page](https://www.sjsu.edu/curriculum/courses/syllabus-info.php) (<https://www.sjsu.edu/curriculum/courses/syllabus-info.php>). Make sure to visit this page to review and be aware of these university policies and resources.

OFFICE HOURS

I am available during in person office hours listed above to talk about the course assignments, study strategies or current events. No appointments are needed. Office hours are by prior appointment only. Please email proposed day and time M-F 9-6 pm for an appointment by phone or Zoom. If you would like to meet by Zoom please email me the Zoom link at least two hours before our scheduled appointment.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS

The required assignments will test your knowledge and ability to apply and assess principles and concepts of US and California government as models of representative democracy.

Key Concepts

This assignment assesses for CLO 1, CLO 3, GEPOs 1, GEPOs 3

Please carefully read the “Assignment Instructions” on Canvas for how to complete this assignment.

Reflection Paper

This assignment assesses for CLO 1, CLO 2, CLO 3, CLO 4, GEPOs 2, GEPOs 3 Please

carefully read the “Assignment Instructions” on Canvas for how to complete this assignment.

SJSU Port Huron Paper

This assignment assesses for CLO 1, CLO 2, CLO 3, CLO 4, GEPOs 2, GEPOs 3 Please

carefully read the “Assignment Instructions” on Canvas for how to complete this assignment.

Extra Credit

Extra credit opportunities will be announced only when campus events related to the class are scheduled. If and when extra credit opportunities are announced you will have the opportunity to have 1 point added to your final grade will be earned as long as the student completes the prompt by the end of the last day of this class. These may be in person only or hybrid depending on the format. However, it is unlikely that there will be any extra credit opportunities during summer.

Grammar and Proofreading

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You will be graded for grammar, punctuation and style to the extent that it reduces your ability to express your research and analysis clearly. While grammar, punctuation, and style are not the most significant part of the grade you will receive, it does affect your ability to communicate your ideas and analysis clearly and effectively. If you have any issues concerning your language skills you wish to discuss with me please visit me during office hours.

Where to Get Help with Your Writing

Although I do not proofread student papers before they are turned in I am happy to help you with specific selections of text. For help I encourage you to first go to the campus writing center for help with your

writing and the campus reference librarians for help with research and citations.

I strongly encourage you to use the SJSU Writing Center's Homegrown Handouts on many aspects of the writing process here: <https://www.sjsu.edu/writingcenter/handouts/>

The Writing Center, <https://www.sjsu.edu/writingcenter/>, also offers up to two 45 minutes sessions per week by emailing them a request at writingcenter@sjsu.edu. It is also partnered with MLK Library to offer live chat services for students who have quick writing-related questions that can be addressed in 10-15 minutes. Live chat is available during select hours and no appointment is necessary.

The reference librarians can also help with using the library databases to find your outside sources and do the APA references (remember to use the Lunsford Guide). You can email or chat live with a librarian on the website here: <https://library.sjsu.edu/ask-librarian/ask-librarian>

For additional resources see:

<https://sjsu.edu/writingcenter/resources/handouts.php>

<https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PLpFC61a1FFT1JpayAOp5gXM7ufxV5wItK>

You may also use the Lib Guide cited above and the short guides to writing research papers at <http://owl.english.purdue.edu/sitemap/>

COURSE SCHEDULE

Notes:

- The schedule is subject to change with fair notice by email or on Canvas.
- Complete the readings **before** the assigned class meetings.
- All bolded text are assignments.
- The number of sets due include all assigned readings and video lectures (which count as one).

Week	Dates	Lecture Topic	Required Readings (pdf's can be found in Canvas Modules)	Assignments Due
Week 1	Mon 7/6	• First day of class • Review syllabus	none	none
Week 1	Wed 7/8	What is Power? Video Lecture	• Ovetz, "It's About Power" • Domhoff "Class and Power in America"	3 sets of Key Concepts due on Canvas by 11:59 pm

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Week 1	Fri 7/10	Authority Video Lecture	• Ovetz, <i>We the Elites</i> , "Introduction: The United States, Democracy or Republic?" (pp. 1-15)" • Milgram, ch. 11 "Process of Obedience" • Machiavelli "On Cruelty and Mercy..." • Thucydides "The Melian Dialogue" • RP Wolff "The Conflict Between Authority and	6 sets of Key Concepts due on Canvas by 11:59 pm
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			Autonomy”	
Week 2	Mon 7/13	Democracy & Dictatorship Video Lecture	• Ovetz, <i>We the Elites</i>, ch. 1 “The Framer’s Vision” (pp. 16-40) • Rosseau “Discourse on Inequality” • Arendt “Total Domination” (pp. 119-145) • Anderson “Private Government” (pp. 37-48) • De Stefano “Silicon Valley’s Anti Democratic Turn Begins at Work” • Justice Jackson dissent, <i>Trump v US</i>	See below
Week 2	Fri 7/17	Democracy & Dictatorship	none	7 sets of Key Concepts due on Canvas by 11:59 pm
Week 3	Mon 7/20	Imperialism & War Video Lecture	• Ovetz, <i>We the Elites</i>, ch. 7 “The Executive: Unrestrained Global Guardian of Property” (pp. 117-127) • Monroe Doctrine & Roosevelt Corollary • Lenin “Imperialism: Highest Stage of Capitalism” (pp. 82-92) • David Cole “Trump’s War” • Fanon “The Wretched of the Earth”	See below
Week 3	Fri 7/24	Imperialism & War	none	6 sets of Key Concepts due on Canvas by 11:59 pm
Week 4	Mon 7/27	Reflection Paper due on Canvas by 11:59 pm	none	none
Week 4	Tues 7/28	Social Control and Divisions Video Lecture	• Foucault “Means of Correct Training” • Plutarch “The Life of Lycurgus” • Robinson, ch. 2 “Savage Inequalities” (read pp. 40 to 70 only) • Combahee River Collective Statement • Asad Haider, ch. 1 “Identity Politics”	See below
Week 4	Fri 7/31	Social Control and Divisions	none	6 sets of Key Concepts due on Canvas by 11:59 pm

Week 5	Mon 8/3	Future Prospects Video Lecture	• Fox Piven and Cloward, “The Weight of the Poor: A Strategy to End Poverty,” <i>The Nation</i>, May 2, 1966 • Van Meter “We Should Demand Democratic Workplaces, But What Does That Mean?” • James “Every Cook Can Govern” • Ovetz, <i>We the Elites</i>, ch. 10 “Beyond the Constitution” (pp. 159-174) • Hampton, “You Can Murder a Liberator, but You Can’t Murder Liberation” • Black Panther Party “Ten-Point Program” • SDS Port Huron Statement (use for your paper)	See below
Week 5	Wed 8/5	Future Prospects	none	8 sets of Key Concepts due on Canvas by 11:59 pm
Week 5	Fri 8/7	Last day of class SJSU Port Huron Paper and all late Readings Key Concepts, and Reflection Paper, due on Canvas by 11:59 pm	none	none